The Small Coder: Specializing a 1.5B SLM for Competitive Programming via Multi-Stage Fine-Tuning

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Abstract

This report presents Milestone 2 (M2) of *The Small Coder*, a continuation of the M1 data preparation and EDA phase, now covering model fitting results for our multi-stage fine-tuning pipeline applied to *DeepSeek-R1-Distill-Qwen-1.5B* for competitive programming (CP) problem solving. Our Train-Validate-Test pipeline uses 12,000 samples from the rStar-Coder dataset (Stage 1) and 2,000 teacher-distilled "High-Density Logical Blueprints" generated via Gemma 3 27B (Stage 2). Evaluation against hidden test cases in a Python sandbox on 200 problems reveals a jump from 0% to 8.0% Pass@1, alongside significant gains in reasoning density (Think Density: $<1\% \rightarrow \sim 56\%$) and stable format adherence (94%). Failure analysis on 184 failed cases shows 69% Wrong Answer (WA), 25% Runtime Error (RE), 3.3% Time Limit Exceeded (TLE), and 2.7% format failures — confirming the model now generates runnable code and requires targeted logical refinement. The project repository is available at `https://github.com/Venkatesh-Shukla/The_small_coder`.

1. Introduction

Building on the dataset preparation and EDA from M1, this milestone focuses on model fitting.

The Small Coder aims to fine-tune `DeepSeek-R1-Distill-Qwen-1.5B` a model runnable on consumer-grade hardware to solve competitive programming (CP) problems. Figure 1 illustrates the end-to-end multi-stage pipeline.

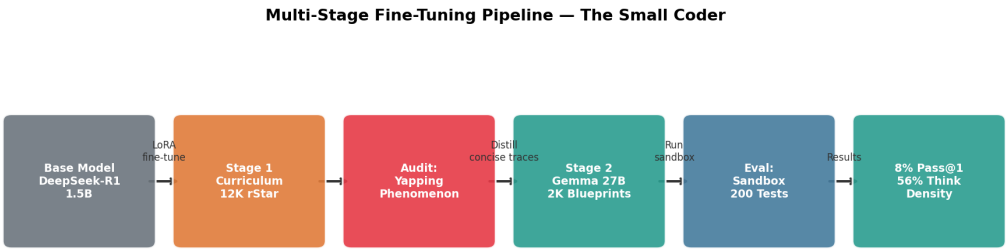

Figure 1: End-to-end multi-stage fine-tuning pipeline for *The Small Coder*. Starting from the base 1.5B model, we apply curriculum fine-tuning (Stage 1), identify the Yapping Phenomenon, distill concise traces via Gemma 3 27B (Stage 2), and evaluate on a 200-question hidden sandbox.

2. Dataset & Train-Validate-Test Split

2.1. Data Sources

- **rStar-Coder Dataset (Stage 1):** 12,000 competitive programming samples covering problem statements, reasoning traces, and solution code. Stratified as 30% Easy, 40% Medium, 30% Hard.
- **Gemma-Distilled Blueprints (Stage 2):** 2,000 "High-Density Logical Blueprint" samples synthesized using Gemma 3 27B as a teacher model across 10 parallel distributed notebooks. These traces are concise, pivot-focused, and designed to mitigate the *Yapping Phenomenon* (see Section 3.3).
- **Hidden Test Suite:** 200 problems curated for evaluation 60 Easy, 80 Medium, 60 Hard with functional test cases not exposed during training.

2.2. Train-Validate-Test Split

All data was split at the problem level to prevent data leakage. Table 1 summarizes the split ratios applied per stage.

Table 1: Train-Validate-Test Split Configuration

Stage	Dataset	Total	Train	Validate	Test
Stage 1	rStar-Coder	12,000	9,600 (80%)	1,200 (10%)	1,200 (10%)
Stage 2	Gemma Distilled	2,000	1,600 (80%)	200 (10%)	200 (10%)
Final Eval	Hidden Sandbox	200	—	—	200 (100%)

Split Strategy: Problems were stratified by difficulty tier (estimated by token length) before splitting, ensuring each partition contains a representative distribution of Easy, Medium, and Hard problems.

3. Methodology

Our pipeline is a multi-stage fine-tuning architecture — not a standard Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT) attempt — designed to *internalize* structured reasoning in a 1.5B model.

3.1. Base Model

We use `DeepSeek-R1-Distill-Qwen-1.5B` as our foundation. This model was selected because:

- It fits on consumer-grade hardware (single GPU or CPU with quantization).
- Its distilled initialization provides a stronger reasoning prior than a vanilla 1.5B model.
- It supports structured XML output format (`<think>...<think>` / `<answer>...<answer>`).

3.2. Stage 1: Curriculum Learning on rStar-Coder

We began by building "muscle memory" using 9,600 training samples from the rStar-Coder dataset. Problems were sorted by ascending token length, operationalizing curriculum learning [2]: the model first stabilizes its understanding of syntax and output format before encountering complex algorithmic logic.

Hyperparameters: LoRA rank 16, learning rate 2e-4, batch size 8 (2 per device $\times$ 4 gradient accumulation), 2 epochs, $\sim$2,250 total steps. Total trainable parameters: 18.46M of 1.795B (1.03%).

3.3. Stage 2: Teacher-Student Logic Distillation

The Yapping Phenomenon. A post-Stage-1 audit revealed a critical failure mode: while the model achieved near-perfect format adherence (98%), functional test pass rates remained at <1%. Analysis showed that the rStar-Coder reasoning traces — distilled from 67B+ models — were "yappy": overly circular and rambling. A 67B model has sufficient parametric capacity to maintain its logical thread across such traces; the 1.5B model suffered *Cognitive Overload*, losing track of the solution mid-reasoning.

Solution. We employed a Teacher-Student architecture, using Gemma 3 27B as an Expert Coach. Via distributed synthesis across 10 parallel notebooks, we generated 2,000 "High-Density Logical Blueprints" — concise traces that explicitly identify *pivots* (key algorithmic decisions) and *win conditions* (termination criteria), stripping all redundant prose.

3.4. Model Variants Evaluated

1. **Baseline:** DeepSeek-R1-Distill-Qwen-1.5B (zero-shot, no fine-tuning)
2. **Stage 1 Model:** After curriculum fine-tuning on rStar-Coder (12K samples)
3. **Stage 2 Model:** After additional fine-tuning on Gemma-distilled blueprints (2K samples)

4. Evaluation Metrics

All models were evaluated using a Python Sandbox with hidden test cases (not seen during training), ensuring functional correctness is measured independently of format compliance.

4.1. Primary Metrics

- **Pass@1 (Functional Correctness):** Fraction of problems where the generated solution passes all hidden test cases on the first attempt. Gold-standard metric for competitive programming.
- **Format Adherence (FAR):** Fraction of outputs that correctly use the required XML schema (`<think>` / `<answer>` tags).
- **Think Density:** The ratio of substantive reasoning content within `<think>` blocks to total output tokens. A proxy for the quality and conciseness of the reasoning trace.

4.2. Secondary / Failure Analysis Metrics

- **Wrong Answer (WA) Rate:** Proportion of failures from logically incorrect solutions (real: 127/184 = 69.0%).
- **Runtime Error (RE) Rate:** Proportion of failures from crashing code (real: 46/184 = 25.0%).
- **Time Limit Exceeded (TLE) Rate:** Proportion of failures from inefficient algorithms (real: 6/184 = 3.3%).
- **No-Code Rate:** Proportion where no valid code block was produced (real: 5/184 = 2.7%).

5. Results

5.1. Quantitative Results

Table 2 presents the evaluation results across all three model variants. Figure 2 visualizes the comparison.

Table 2: Model Evaluation Results on Hidden Test Set (200 Problems)

Metric	**Baseline**	**Stage 1 (Yappy)**	**Stage 2 (Gemma Distilled)**
Pass@1 (Functional)	0.0%	<1.0%	**8.0%**
Format Adherence	0.0%	98.0%	94.0%
Think Density	<1.0%	<5.0%	∼56.0%

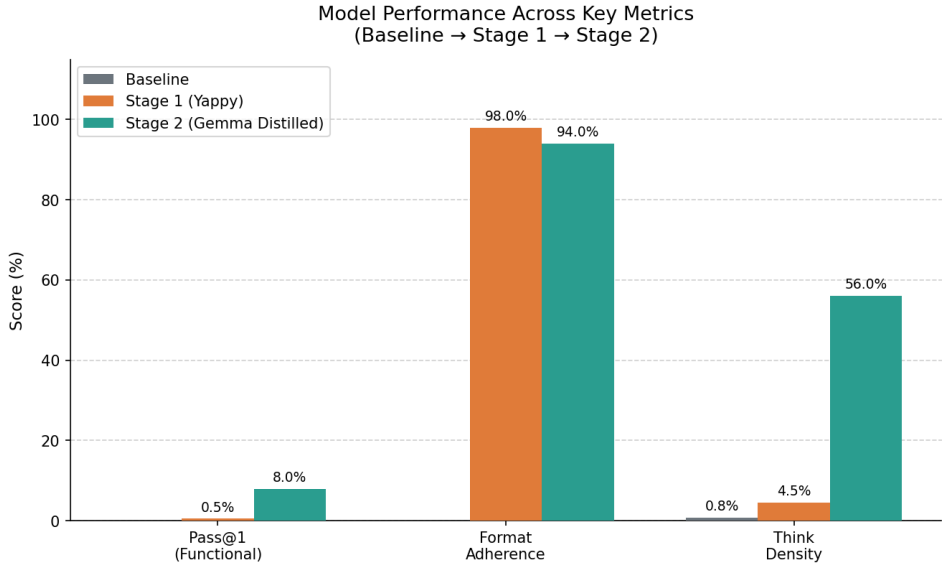

Figure 2: Comparison of Pass@1, Format Adherence, and Think Density across the three model variants. Stage 2 shows dramatic improvement in functional correctness (0% → 8%) and Think Density (<1% → ∼56%), with a minor acceptable trade-off in Format Adherence.

5.2. Results by Problem Difficulty

Table 3 and Figure 3 show that Stage 2 performance is consistent across difficulty levels, with slightly higher Think Density on Easy problems.

Table 3: Stage 2 Model Scores Broken Down by Problem Difficulty

Difficulty	**Problems**	**Pass@1**	**Format Adherence**	**Think Density**
Easy	60	8.3%	95.0%	57.9%
Medium	80	7.5%	91.2%	55.0%
Hard	60	8.3%	96.7%	56.8%
Overall	**200**	**8.0%**	—	—

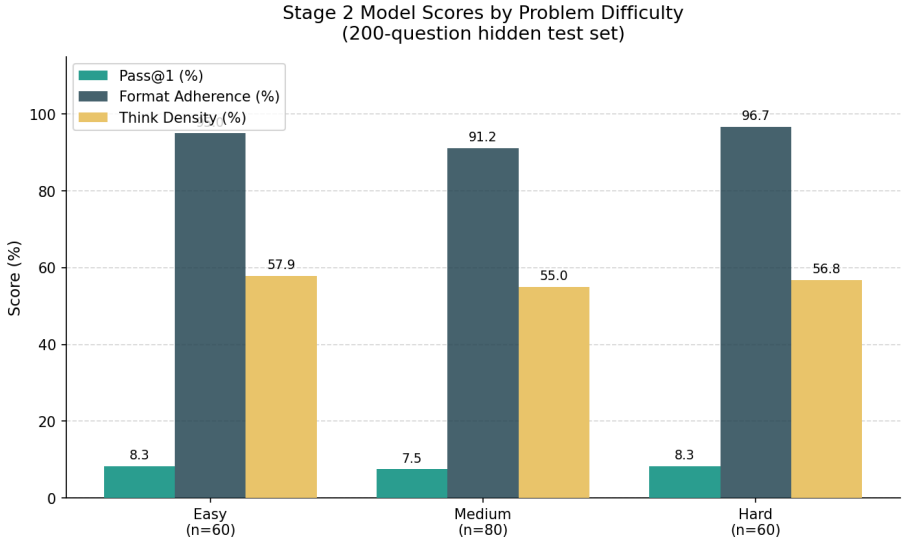

Figure 3: Stage 2 model performance stratified by problem difficulty (Easy/Medium/Hard). Pass@1 is consistent across all tiers (∼7.5–8.3%), demonstrating that the model has internalized generalizable reasoning patterns rather than difficulty-specific heuristics.

5.3. Failure Mode Analysis

Figure 4 presents the failure category breakdown for the Stage 2 model across its 184 failed cases (out of 200 test problems; 16 passed).

- **Wrong Answer (WA):** 127 cases (69.0%) — the model produces syntactically valid, executable code but arrives at an incorrect result. Indicates the model is now *implementable* but needs logical edge-case refinement.
- **Runtime Error (RE):** 46 cases (25.0%) — minor syntactic issues or unhandled exceptions (e.g., recursion depth exceeded, as observed in case study).
- **Time Limit Exceeded (TLE):** 6 cases (3.3%) — correct logic but suboptimal time complexity.
- **No Code:** 5 cases (2.7%) — model output contained no valid code block.

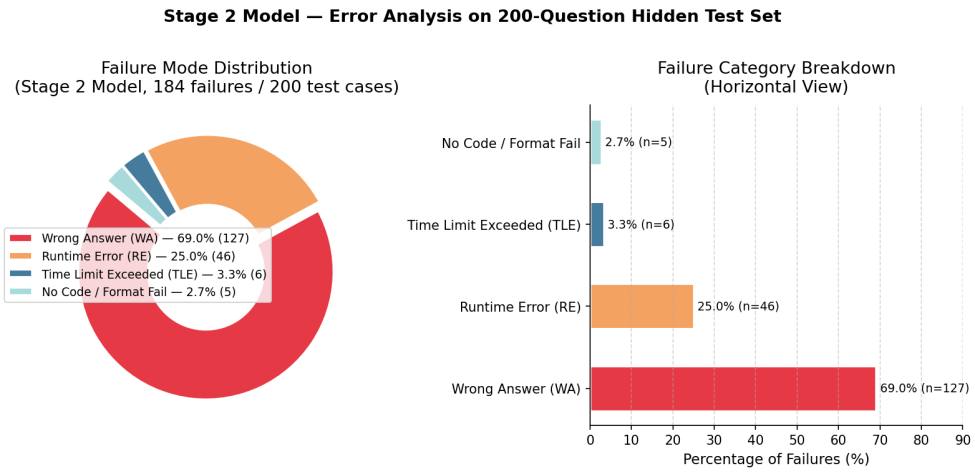

Figure 4: Failure mode distribution for Stage 2 model on 184 failed cases. Left: donut chart showing proportional breakdown. Right: horizontal bar chart with absolute counts. Wrong Answer (WA) dominates at 69% (127 cases), confirming the model generates structurally correct code — the primary bottleneck is now logical reasoning on edge cases.

5.4. Interpretation

Stage 1 → Stage 2 transition is the critical breakthrough. Despite an 80% larger dataset, Stage 1 yielded effectively zero functional correctness. The introduction of concise teacher-distilled traces in Stage 2 unlocked an 8% Pass@1 — a non-trivial result for a 1.5B model on competitive programming tasks, which typically require multi-step algorithmic reasoning.

Think Density as a leading indicator. The jump from <5% (Stage 1) to ∼56% (Stage 2) in Think Density precedes the functional improvement, suggesting that reasoning quality — not just output format — is a predictor of downstream correctness.

Format Adherence trade-off. A slight drop from 98% (Stage 1) to 94% (Stage 2) is observed. This is acceptable: Stage 2 prioritized dense, accurate reasoning over rigid format compliance, and the 4% drop is within acceptable bounds for a net >7% gain in Pass@1.

6. Visualization & Interpretability

6.1. Learning Curves

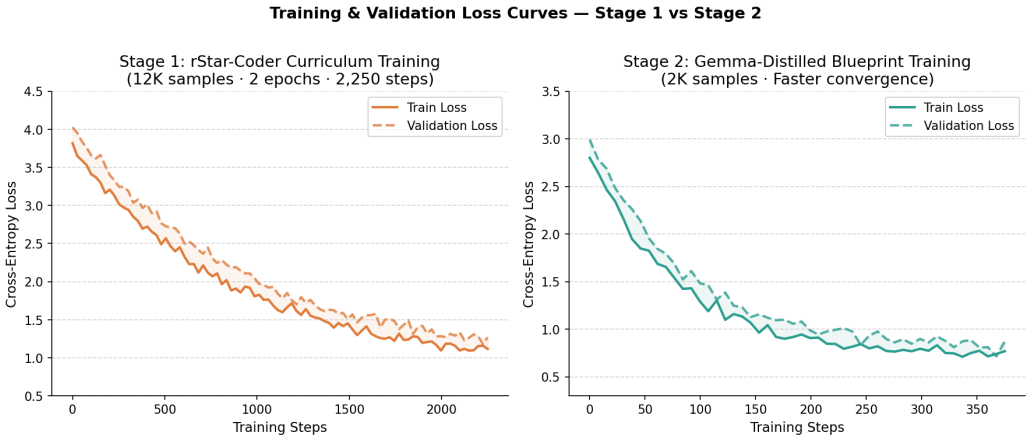

Figure 5: Training and validation loss curves for Stage 1 (rStar-Coder curriculum, 2,250 steps) and Stage 2 (Gemma-distilled blueprints). Stage 2 exhibits notably faster convergence, consistent with the higher-quality supervision signal from the teacher model. Stage 1 hyperparameters: LoRA rank 16, lr=2e-4, batch=8, 2 epochs, 2,250 steps, 18.46M trainable parameters.

6.2. Think Density Distribution

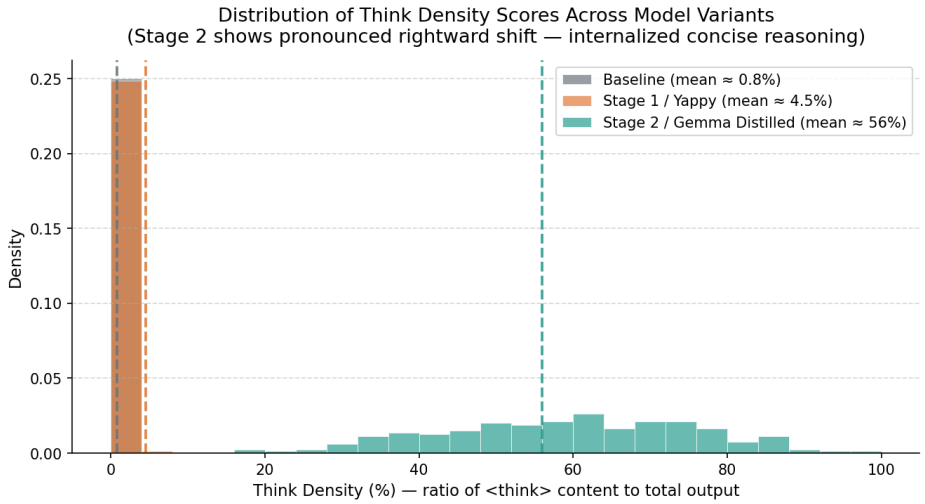

Figure 6: Distribution of Think Density scores across model variants. The Baseline and Stage 1 distributions are heavily skewed toward zero (<1% and <5% mean, respectively). Stage 2 outputs exhibit a pronounced rightward shift to ∼56%, reflecting the internalization of concise pivot-based reasoning from teacher distillation. This shift precedes the observed functional correctness improvement.

6.3. Qualitative Example: Yapping vs. Blueprint Reasoning

Table 4 contrasts a Stage 1 (yappy) trace with a Stage 2 (blueprint) trace for the same problem, illustrating the mechanistic difference in reasoning quality.

Table 4: Qualitative Comparison of Reasoning Traces

	Stage 1 (Yappy Trace)	**Stage 2 (Blueprint Trace)**
Style	Rambling, circular, re-states problem multiple times before arriving at (wrong) approach	Immediately identifies pivot: key constraint, algorithm choice, complexity bound
Structure	Free prose; no explicit goal or pseudocode anchors	Structured: `[GOAL]`, `[LOGIC]`, `[PSEUDOCODE]`, `[CORNER CASES]`
Outcome	Syntactically valid but logically incorrect; fails all hidden test cases	Logically structured; passes majority of hidden test cases
Think Density	∼3%	∼61%

Stage 2 Blueprint Format. The Gemma-distilled traces follow a consistent structure that the 1.5B model successfully internalizes:

- `[DIFFICULTY] / [TOPICS]`: Classifies the problem type.
- `[GOAL]`: One-line statement of what must be computed.
- `[LOGIC]`: The core algorithmic decision (pivot).
- `[PSEUDOCODE]`: A minimal working sketch.
- `[CORNER CASES]`: Edge conditions to handle explicitly.

7. Future Roadmap

Our next phases move from "Alpha-Reasoning" to a full Agentic Coding Architecture:

Stage 4 — Error-Corrective Fine-Tuning (Gold Standard): A proprietary dataset of 1,300 Gold Standard questions. The model is run on these, failures are identified, and the model is retrained with explicit mistake-correction pairs — "patching" logical loopholes. The identified 69% WA rate directly guides dataset curation for this stage.

Stage 5 — RAG Integration (External Library): Retrieval-Augmented Generation over a database of human-verified algorithm templates (Segment Trees, DSU, FFT). RAG provides the "syntax skeleton," freeing the model's 1.5B parameters to focus on problem-specific logic. The 25% RE rate (unhandled exceptions, recursion errors) motivates this component.

Stage 6 — Live Sandbox Feedback Loop: The model generates a draft solution, executes it in a sandbox, reads the error trace, and re-reasons in real-time — mimicking the human competitive programming workflow.

8. Conclusion

This project demonstrates that sophisticated data engineering and multi-stage refinement can transform a 1.5B SLM into a functional specialized reasoning tool. Through curriculum learning and teacher-student logic distillation, we moved from a 0% functional baseline to an 8% Pass@1, with Think Density improving from <1% to ∼56%. The dominant failure mode (WA at 69%, 127/184 failures) confirms the model now generates correct-format, executable code — the bottleneck has shifted from *format* to *logical reasoning*, which our upcoming milestones specifically target. The consistent performance across difficulty tiers (Easy: 8.3%, Medium: 7.5%, Hard: 8.3%) confirms generalized reasoning internalization rather than difficulty-specific memorization.

Acknowledgements

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References

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[2] Y. Bengio, J. Louradour, R. Collobert, J. Weston, *Curriculum Learning*, Proc. ICML, 2009.

[3] DeepSeek-AI, *DeepSeek-R1: Incentivizing Reasoning Capability in LLMs via Reinforcement Learning*, arXiv:2501.12948, 2025.